

W. Anthony Sheppard, in an *Oxford Bibliographies* entry, describes the phenomenon of exoticism: “In much of the extensive literature on the subject, exoticism is considered a form of representation in which peoples, places, and cultural practices are depicted as foreign from the perspective of the composer and/or intended audience. In earlier usage of the term, ‘exoticism’ and ‘exotic’ referred to an inherent quality or status of the non-Western other.”¹

Giacomo Puccini’s *Madama Butterfly* is a unique piece of exoticism art because it exhibits not one unfamiliar culture (to the composer and librettists), but two. As Cio-Cio San’s Japanese culture comes in ruinous contact with Lieutenant Pinkerton’s American traditions, both fall under Sheppard’s definition of being “foreign” to the Italians Puccini, Illica, and Giacosa. The study that follows will document Puccini’s effort to illustrate a musically vivid Japan, or the superficial European idea of Japan at the time, through musical borrowing of Japanese popular and folk music. It will specifically focus on Puccini’s acquisition and borrowing of several popular Japanese melodies in his effort to create an exotic musical mosaic. By contrast, I will discuss the stereotypical American ideology as well as Puccini’s depiction of the American characters in *Madama Butterfly* as contributors to a piece of anti-imperialist, and potentially anti-American art through their condescension to, and exploitation of the colonial Japanese.

Japonisme, a branch of the exoticism movement previously described, exploded on the European art scene in the nineteenth century after new technologies opened the eyes of the Western world to previously unexplored Eastern lands. Japan had been closed to the outside world for more than two hundred years; a fact that increased the excitement in 1860 when Japan began to allow easier access to foreigners. In a catalogue for a 1992 exhibition in Kyoto, museum director

¹ Sheppard, W. Anthony. "Exoticism." Exoticism. <http://www.oxfordbibliographies.com/view/document/obo-9780199757824/obo-9780199757824-0123.xml> (accessed April 21, 2014).

Oshima Seiji wrote “...the dynamic effect of Japonisme was due to the combined stimulation of its exotic strangeness and its meaningful content.”² Japanese art came to the West during a time when European artists were seeking ways to move away from the traditional formulas and methods of the official schools and salons. Jan van Rij explains that “Japonisme, overcoming its exotic phase, became one of the models that stimulated an avant-garde of painters, etchers, sculptors, and architects, among them Édouard Manet, Claude Monet, Edgar Degas, Henri Toulouse-Lautrec,... Vincent van Gogh,... James McNeill Whistler [and others].”³ Though Japonisme had great influence on the visual arts, it also had considerable influence in music. Music critic Michel Fleury observes, “The assimilation by western music of elements borrowed from the Asian or Arab East should be seen in parallel with the influence of Japanese painting on Whistler or Manet.”⁴

Prior to Puccini’s *Madama Butterfly*, in terms of Japonisme in opera, came Saint-Saëns’ opera *La Princesse Jaune*, (The Yellow Princess) which, with its use of pentatonic scales and a few borrowed Japanese popular tunes, became the first Western musical work with a Japanese theme and employing a Japanese musical technique. Mascagni’s 1898 opera *Iris* was also a predecessor of Puccini’s work on a Japanese theme, for which Luigi Illica, Puccini’s librettist, penned the text. Mascagni did not bother to utilize Japanese techniques or borrow Japanese tunes but rather relied on the synthesis of Japanese themes in the Italian style. Upon seeing Mascagni’s opera, Puccini remarked that he admired the instrumentation but found the dramatic structure left

² Rij, Jan van. *Madame Butterfly: Japonisme, Puccini, & the Search for the Real Cho-Cho-San*. (Berkeley, Calif: Stone Bridge Press, 2001): 38.

³ Rij: 39-40.

⁴ Rij: 45.

much to be desired.⁵ Between 1870 and 1895, a slew of operettas, light comedies, and musical comedies adopted Japanese themes, the most well known of which remains the Gilbert and Sullivan operetta *The Mikado*.

Puccini had the idea for *Madama Butterfly* as soon as he saw David Belasco's one-act play, *Madame Butterfly*, an adaptation of John Luther Long's short story of the same name, at the Duke of York's Theatre on 21 June, 1900 while visiting London for the first production of *Tosca* at Covent Garden. Belasco's *Madame Butterfly* was based on a short story of the same name by John Luther Long, which first appeared in *Century Magazine* in 1898. Although Puccini could not have understood much of the English language play, it had a great impact on him. The composer later wrote that it was like "pouring gasoline on an open fire."⁶ He decided at once that he would adapt the play for his next opera and, with tears still in his eyes, approached Belasco about an operatic adaptation. Once given the permission to adapt the play, Puccini would continue his collaboration with Luigi Illica and Giuseppe Giacosa, his librettist team for *La Bohème* and *Tosca*.

In January of 1902, with the libretti for the first two acts under revision, Puccini was ready to begin composing. He wrote to Illica: "I've now embarked for Japan and will do my best to represent it, but more than publications on social and material culture I need some notes of popular music!... I've looked for and found it, but it's scanty and not very good."⁷ As is evidenced in this letter, Puccini did have a genuine desire to not only replicate the perceived sounds,

⁵ Rij: 48.

⁶ Groos, A. 1999. "Cio-Cio-San and Sadayakko: Japanese Music-Theater in *Madama Butterfly*". *MONUMENTA NIPPONICA*. 54, no. 1 (Tokyo, Japan): 41.

⁷ Groos: 45.

customs, and traditions of Japan from the fascinated perspective of European Japonisme, but also aspired to obtain authentic Japanese popular music and do justice to the story and culture that had so moved him upon viewing Belasco's adaptation.

In Autumn of 1902, to facilitate his search for authentic Japanese melodies, Puccini made contact with Ōyamo Hisako, wife of the Japanese ambassador to Italy, about whose visit he gives details in a letter to his publisher Giulio Ricordi: "I've now had a visit by Madame Ōyamo, the wife of the Japanese ambassador. She has told me many interesting things and has sung 'native' songs for me. She has promised to send me music from her country... The ambassador is at Viareggio and I'll go there and make notes of what she sings for me."⁸ Later the composer wrote: "The Japanese minister's wife has visited me several times. She has written to Tokyo to obtain popular songs, but it will take three months to get them! They'll be useful for the other acts!"⁹

Puccini scholar Arthur Groos points out, however, that Madame Ōyamo's request to Tokyo on Puccini's behalf came too late to be considered a primary source of the popular Japanese melodies found in the opera. Puccini completed Act I of *Madama Butterfly* in late November 1902 and Act II in January 1903. This means that any music requested in late 1902 or early 1903 could only have been used in the final scenes of the opera or in the revision of already composed material. Puccini must have had access to prior sources for borrowings that exist throughout the opera.

Since Puccini did not document the sources of his borrowings, musicologists have attempted to piece together what may have been available to Puccini and compare it with what is

⁸ Groos: 47.

⁹ Ibid.

found in the *Madama Butterfly* score. Two sources, as researched by musicologists Arthur Groos, Kunio Hara, and Kimiyo Powils-Okano stand out as the probable origin of the borrowings. The first being the performances of the first Japanese theater troupe to tour Europe.

The “Imperial Japanese Theatrical Company,” led by Kawakami Otojirō and Sadayakko, a koto and shamisen virtuoso, was in the thick of a second European tour during the years of Puccini’s work on *Madama Butterfly*. The tour began in England in April 1901 and covered a number of Italian cities between March and May 1902. Puccini wrote to Ricordi on 23 April, 1902: “Illica has written to tell me to interview the Japanese woman Sada Yacco. If you think so too, I could make an excursion when she comes to Milan. An interpreter will be necessary, but she’ll certainly speak some European language.”¹⁰ Unfortunately, when Puccini arrived at Milan no interpreter could be located and Sadayakko was not fluent in any European tongue. Puccini wrote Illica on 30 April, 1902: “I’m working. And I did not interview Sada Yacco. But I have here a lot of material of the yellow race that will do for me.”¹¹ What material could that have been? According to Groos, the postmarks on his correspondence place Puccini in Milan from April 24 to April 29 where he likely attended troupe performances which, during those days, included Sadayakko’s virtuosic koto performance of “Echigo jishi”. (Example 1) The performance precedes Puccini’s use of the same melody in the *Butterfly* score by only a few days. Following Lt. Pinkerton’s selfish exclamation in Act I of his intention to someday marry a “*vera sposa americana*,” the music changes to a 2/4 *allegro* as Goro sings the melody of “Echigo jishi” to announce the arrival of Cio-Cio San and her friends. (Example 2)

¹⁰ Groos: 50.

¹¹ Ibid.

Example 1. “Echigo jishi” in Nagai and Kobatake 1891.



Example 2. Goro announces the arrival of Butterfly to the tune of “Echigo jishi.”

Allegro ♩ = 144

Go. *Ec-co! Son giun-te al som-mo del pen-dio. Già del fem-mi-ne o*

(37)

Go. *scia-me qual di ven-to in fo-glia-me s'o-de il bru-si-o*

The second source from which Puccini likely gathered the majority of his borrowings for the opera was a two-volume collection of piano arrangements by Polish composer Rudolph Dittrich. According to Kunio Hara, “Rudolph Dittrich’s collections of piano arrangements of Japanese melodies, *Nippon Gafuku* (1894 and 1895), are two of the most significant source materi-

als for Japanese music that Puccini consulted in his creation of *Madama Butterfly*... Despite the obscurity of Dittrich and his works, a careful examination of *Nippon Gafuku* confirms Puccini's familiarity with the music in these collections and enlightens significantly Puccini's compositional process."¹²

During the 1870s, when the Meiji government of Japan finally opened its borders to foreigners, it began to emulate Western nations as social and political models of modern society. In 1872, it established a national education system, also based upon Western models, and looked toward American and European music education. A government committee, known as the "Music Investigation Committee" was created in order to investigate Japanese and Western music, create music textbooks, and train music teachers. The Meiji government hired musicians from Europe and the United States to aid in this project. These were the rare circumstances that gave Galicia-born (modern Poland) violinist/organist/composer Rudolph Dittrich access to Japanese musicians and their music.

Dittrich (1861-1919), studied at the Wiener Konservatorium from 1878 to 1882 under Hellmesberger and Bruckner. He worked as a freelance musician in Vienna until 1888 when he received the invitation to Tokyo. Once in Tokyo, Dittrich worked for the Tokyo Music School (to which the Music Investigation Committee changed its name in 1887) as an artistic director, a teacher of violin, harmony, composition, and an editor and arranger of school songs. His post at the music school and his relationship with many Japanese musicians exposed him to a significant amount of Japanese music. In 1894, the advent of the Sino-Japanese war forced Dittrich to return to Vienna where he took advantage of the Japonisme trend of the period and used his knowledge

¹² Hara, Kunio. *Rudolf Dittrich's Nippon Gakufu and Giacomo Puccini's Madama Butterfly*. *Music Research Forum* 19 (2004): 3.

of popular Japanese melodies to compose his collections of piano arrangements. The first volume of *Nippon Gafuku* was published in 1894 and consisted of piano arrangements of six “Japanische Volkslieder/Japanese Popular Songs.”¹³ His second collection, published the following year, contained arrangements of ten additional “Japanische Lieder/Japanese Songs.”¹⁴

In perfect alignment with *Madama Butterfly*’s synthesis of Eastern and Western influences, Dittrich’s collections boasted an oriental/occidental union. Hara explains: “In Dittrich’s *Nippon Gafuku*, Japanese melodies are completely assimilated into the normative musical language of the late nineteenth-century Western European tradition, making the collection devoid of any hints of Japanese influence beside the original melodies one might expect to find in such a collection.”¹⁵ Dittrich’s decision to arrange the Japanese melodies in a Western European style aligns also with his duties for the Meiji government. The Music Investigation Committee sought a Japanese/Western composite for music education. Dittrich was likely providing similar arrangements as an arranger/editor for the Tokyo Music School.

Giacomo Puccini would have had access to Dittrich’s *Nippon Gafuku* which was published by Breitkopf & Härtel and appeared several years before Puccini began composing the *Madama Butterfly*. Puccini borrowed four *Nippon Gafuku* melodies for inclusion in the *Butterfly* score: “Ha-Uta,” “Sakura,” “O Yedo Nihon-Bashi,” and “Jizuki-Uta.”

“Ha-Uta” is one of two songs from the Dittrich collections that lack lyrics. Since the songs, according to Hara, likely contained vulgar texts which were inappropriate for students,

¹³ Hara: 7.

¹⁴ Ibid.

¹⁵ Ibid.

Dittrich's colleagues refused to reveal them.¹⁶ In *Madama Butterfly*, fragments of "Ha-Uta" and "Sakura" appear in Act I when Cio-Cio San and Pinkerton seek sanctuary in their new house before the wedding ceremony so Cio-Cio San can show her "*pochi oggetti da donna*" to her soon-to-be husband. Dittrich's opening chord of "Ha-Uta" is composed of two interlocking fifths (A-E and E-B). Puccini modifies the harmony by substituting the doubled E with F-sharp, stacking three perfect fifths (A-E, E-B, B-F-sharp).¹⁷ The added F-sharp executes a modal shift from Dittrich's original A minor to Puccini's A major. Short melodic fragments reappear four more times in the remainder of the scene in the original A minor as arranged by Dittrich.¹⁸ (Examples 3a - 3c)

Example 3a. Dittrich, "Ha-Uta," mm. 1-3



¹⁶ Hara: 8.

¹⁷ Hara: 10.

¹⁸ Ibid.

Example 3b. Puccini, *Madama Butterfly*, Act I, 74.

Butterfly

Pinkerton

In vor - re - i... po - chi ogget - ti da don - na... Dove sono?

74

f *p*

Example 3c. Puccini, *Madama Butterfly*, Act I, 75.

Butterfly

Faz - zo - let - ti. La pi - pa.

75

pp

As mentioned previously, Puccini also incorporates the popular melody “Sakura” into the same scene. Dittrich’s melody and harmonic structures remain intact. Puccini slightly alters the

harmony and the key is changed from D minor to E minor to allow for a smoother modulation from A minor.¹⁹ (Examples 4a and 4b.)

The opening phrase of “O Yedo Nihon-Bashi” appears unmistakably in the Act I wedding scene. “The first five measures of the passage in E minor immediately following the Japanese official and Goro’s announcement of the newlywed couple are almost identical to 4-8 of Dittrich’s piece in its melodic and harmonic structure.”²⁰ Both are also found in the key of E major. “In Act II, when Sharpless visits Cio-Cio San, the passage reappears in E minor with slight rhythmic and harmonic modifications.”²¹ (Examples 5a-5c)

Example 4a. Dittrich, “Sakura,” mm. 5-10.



¹⁹ Hara: 11.

²⁰ Hara: 12.

²¹ Ibid.

Example 4b. Puccini, *Madama Butterfly*, Act I, five measures after 75.

Butterfly

U-na cin-to-ra. Un pic-co-lo fer-ma-glio. U-no spec-chio. Un ven-ta-glio.

Pinkerton

Butterfly

Pinkerton

Butterfly

Quel ba-rat-to-lo? Un va-so di tin-tu-m, Ohi-bò! Vi spia-ce?...

Example 5a. Dittrich, "O Yedo Nihon-Bashi," mm. 4-9.

mp *mf* *mp* *mf*

Tea * Tea * Tea * Tea * Tea * Tea * Tea *

Example 5b. Puccini, *Madama Butterfly*, Act I, 87.

The musical score for Example 5b, Act I, 87 of *Madama Butterfly*, is in 2/4 time and D major. It begins with a piano introduction in the right hand, marked *f* (forte), followed by a *p* (piano) section. The left hand provides harmonic support with chords and single notes. The vocal entries are as follows:

- Friends:** Ma - da - ma But - ter - fly!...
- Butterfly:** Ma - da - ma F. B. Pin - ker - ton.

Example 5c. Puccini, *Madama Butterfly*. Act II, one measure before 18.

The musical score for Example 5c, Act II, one measure before 18 of *Madama Butterfly*, is in 2/4 time and D major. It features vocal entries for Butterfly and Sharpless, and a piano accompaniment. The score is marked *mf* (mezzo-forte). The vocal entries are as follows:

- Butterfly:** Ma-da - na Pin-ker-ton, Pre-go.
- Sharpless:** Ma-da-na But-ter - fly...

Hara describes the use of the final Japanese melody, which is the most convincing evidence of Puccini's use of the Dittrich collections as well as Puccini's modifications to "Jizuki-Uta:"

While the previous examples of borrowings are fragmentary, Puccini uses the entire structure of "Jizuki-Uta" in order to compose Cio-Cio San's Act II aria, "Che tua madre." The first eleven measures of her aria correspond almost exactly, both melodically and harmonically, to the opening of Dittrich's work (Examples 6a and 6b). Puccini's passage is in A-flat minor, as opposed to Dittrich's in A minor, and Puccini deviates slightly from the original in measure 7, reshaping the music neatly into two four-measure antecedent and consequent phrases. In the original piece, a contrasting "chorus of workmen" follows this passage, characterized by the bold, march-like accompaniment in octaves in the left hand. In the aria, Puccini substitutes equally contrasting material for this section, borrowing a Japanese song "Suiryō-bushi" from Ywai Nagai and Kenpachirō Kobatake's *A Collection of Japanese Popular Musics / Nippon zokkyoku shū* (1891).²²

The close similarity of the examples brought up by Hara leads one to trust the assertion that the Dittrich collections were indeed among the primary sources trusted by Puccini as he established the exotic Japanese tone that would pervade his opera. From Dittrich's pen to Puccini's mind, it helped establish the Japonisme flavor that was so popular at the time, but allowed it to remain truly European, influenced by Massenet and Verdi as were the majority of the Puccini masterworks. Hara also argues that the Dittrich arrangements were specifically used by Puccini during moments of Cio-Cio San's psychological struggle of Eastern vs. Western cultural values. An example is evident in the recurring thematic material of "O Yedo Nihon-Bashi" which is first heard as Butterfly corrects her friends in the wedding party after being addressed as Madama Butterfly rather than Madama Pinkerton. Three years later, Cio-Cio San retains her loyalty to the

²² Hara: 14.

Pinkerton name as Sharpless addresses her as Madama Butterfly. Without even knowing who calls at the door, she corrects Sharpless with a gentle rebuke of “*Madama Pinkerton. Prego.*” In this moment Puccini brings back “O Yedo Nihon-Bashi” to remind the audience of the similar event in Act I as confirmation of her unfailing loyalty and blind belief in Pinkerton’s return.

Example 6a. Dittrich, “Jizuki-Uta.”

The musical score for "Jizuki-Uta" by Dittrich is presented in four systems. The first system is marked "Comodo. M. M. ♩ = 96" and "solo." It begins with a piano introduction in the left hand marked *p*, followed by a vocal melody in the right hand marked *mp*. The second system continues the vocal melody with a *mf* piano accompaniment. The third system, marked "Coro.", features a more complex piano accompaniment with triplets and a vocal melody marked *ff*. The fourth system continues the vocal melody with a *fff* piano accompaniment, including triplets and a final *mp* section.

Example 6b. Puccini, *Madama Butterfly*, Act II, “Che tua madre.”

Butterfly

Che tua ma-dre do-vrà pren-der-ti in brae-ciu ed al-la piog-gia

ppp

e al vento an-dar per la cit-tà a gua-dag nar si il pane e il ve-sti-men-to.

As previously mentioned, Puccini documented in a letter to Illica that he had a desire to “do [his] best to represent [Japan].” The majority of the borrowings found in *Madama Butterfly* are authentic melodies of Japan, which leads most scholars to paint Puccini in the light of having yearned for Japanese authenticity, and not simple superficial approximations of what Europeans thought sounded “exotic” or “Eastern.” Recent findings, however, may provide a new portrait of Puccini’s approach to exoticism.

In June 2012, W. Anthony Sheppard wrote an article for *The New York Times* in which he recounts the story of his discovery of a music box at the Morris Museum in Morristown, New Jersey, which plays Chinese tunes and may have been the source of two unknown melodies in *Madama Butterfly* previously thought to have been of Japanese origin. Sheppard relates:

...Even now few visitors spend much time in the room where Swiss music boxes are displayed. Yet, being a musicologist, I lingered there alone last January as my children ran ahead. I kept listening to one box in particular. A harmoniphone from around 1877, equipped with a reed organ and able to play six Chinese tunes from a cylinder.

Confused at first, I suddenly realized I had stumbled on the key to a musicological mystery many decades old. Scholars have long known that Puccini used Chinese tunes in his opera *Turandot* (set in China and left incomplete on Puccini's death in 1924). But they have been puzzled by the origins of two "Japanese" tunes in his *Madama Butterfly* (set in Japan and first performed in 1904). What I had found were *Chinese* sources for two major themes in *Butterfly* and a surprising connection between that opera and *Turandot*.²³

Sheppard goes on to explain that Puccini had listened to a Chinese music box in 1920 at the home of Baron Edoardo Fassini-Camossi, who was a veteran of the Chinese Boxer Rebellion in 1900 and acquired the box during his time in China. Three of the tunes from the Fassini music box were prominently featured in *Turandot*. The Guinness box (from the Murtoth D. Guinness Collection of mechanical musical instruments and automata) at the Morris Museum also contains two of the *Turandot* melodies but also a principal theme from *Madama Butterfly* which was applied to the Act I love duet between Cio-Cio San and Pinkerton. Evidence shows that the Guinness box may also have been owned by the Fassinis (Puccini knew the family and was a close friend of the Baron's brother, Alberto) and heard by Puccini around the time he was drafting

²³ Sheppard, W. Anthony. "Music Box as Muse to Puccini's 'Butterfly.'" *New York Times*, June 15, 2012.

Madama Butterfly in 1901 and 1902. Sheppard wrote: “Puccini used several popular Japanese tunes in “Butterfly,” including “Sakura, Sakura” and “Miya Sama,” but the Guinness box reveals that around 1901 he was apparently willing to use Chinese music as well in his representations of what he termed the “yellow race.”²⁴ He continued to discuss the subject of the lost melody’s text:

For decades, in an effort to reconstruct Puccini’s models, scholars have been stitching together fragments of published Japanese songs that he might have seen. Fortunately the Guinness box includes its original tune sheet, listing the folk-song titles in Chinese and in transliteration, which turns this music box into a Rosetta stone. The main theme for *Butterfly*, a geisha, is labeled “She Pah Moh” on the tune sheet. Some musicological detective work, with help from the Chinese language scholars Cornelius C. Kubler and Ping Wang, identified the tune as “Shiba Mo,” or “The 18 Touches,” an erotic song often banned in China. This folk song, which also turns up in Chinese operas, is delivered in the voice of a male lover celebrating 18 parts of a woman’s body in explicit detail, moving caress by caress from head to toe.

The specific moments when “Shiba Mo” appears in “*Madama Butterfly*” and Puccini’s sense of humor, said to have been rakish, suggest that he knew what the song was about. The melody appears prominently at the climax to *Butterfly*’s entrance, as she presents herself to her lustful American bridegroom, Lieutenant Pinkerton. *Butterfly* sings the whole melody, in the same key as on the Guinness music box, as she explains to Pinkerton that she has severed all ties to her Japanese past and will devote herself entirely to him. The tune also appears at the climax of the Act I love duet, as Pinkerton eagerly leads *Butterfly* into the house to consummate their marriage.²⁵

This new evidence and research has contributed additional understanding and insight into Puccini’s desire (or lack thereof) for authenticity. It appears he was content to use Chinese melodies as well as Japanese and that his work may not have been an exception to the normative

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ Ibid.

European paradigm of enthusiasm towards exoticism art, which was principally ambience over authenticity.

The other extreme of the cultural spectrum observed in Puccini's *Madama Butterfly* is his depiction of America. The opera is extremely popular in the United States, though according to John Louis DiGaetani, it is "in part an allegory about the subtle devices [American] imperialism uses to exploit the native colonial."²⁶ American audiences, however, do not typically perceive the anti-imperialistic, anti-American message within the love tale. In his essay "The American Presence in *Madama Butterfly*," DiGaetani points out that Sharpless and Pinkerton are both in Nagasaki for a reason. Sharpless's function is diplomatic, but what of Pinkerton?

In 1904, the year of *Madama Butterfly*'s premiere as well as the year in which the opera is set, Theodore Roosevelt, one of America's most imperialistic leaders in history, was president. He first attracted national attention with his participation in the Spanish-American war, which the United States fought for possession of Cuba. Roosevelt was William McKinley's running mate in the campaign of 1900, and became president when McKinley was assassinated in 1901. Roosevelt held the office until 1909. Formerly, during his time as McKinley's Vice President, Roosevelt encouraged the president to aid European powers in crushing China's Boxer Rebellion of 1900: China's attempt to rid itself of foreign domination, which eventually led to Roosevelt's open door policy, allowing all nations equal access to the colonization of Chinese lands. DiGaetani asserts that "Theodore Roosevelt had no qualms about joining in since he felt 'chinks' as he

²⁶ DiGaetani, John Louis. *Puccini the Thinker: The Composer's Intellectual and Dramatic Development*. (Bern: P. Lang, 1987): 116.

usually called them, would benefit from being forced to trade with the U.S., but he didn't want such inferiors emigrating here and limited their legal entry through American emigration laws."²⁷

Historians consider Roosevelt to be "one of the leaders most responsible for America's continued and obstreperous presence around the world."²⁸ Roosevelt was responsible for the domination of the Panama Canal region for American interests, as well as solidifying control over the Hawaiian Islands, Phillipines, Puerto Rico, and other various islands in the Pacific. Roosevelt's slogan came from an old African proverb "Speak softly and carry a big stick, and you will go far." His administration's foreign policy soon adopted this slogan and brandished the "big stick" of the American military on several occasions during his presidency. A disciple of Alfred T. Mahan and Rudyard Kipling, Roosevelt believed in the superiority of the white race, in the need for an Expansionist (even Imperialist) mindset, as well as such racist clichés as "manifest destiny" and "the white man's burden."

While DiGaetani's rhetoric and selectivity to historical facts seems slanted and dismisses much of the good done by Roosevelt, it appropriately frames the mindset and presence of the American military in Nagasaki in 1904. Pinkerton's battleship would likely have been part of Roosevelt's "big stick" policy by defending American merchants from Japanese retribution or perhaps to guard the Chinese coast following the quelling of its "rebellion." By the end of the nineteenth century, Nagasaki had become a "rest and relaxation" port for American sailors, who would often use Nagasaki geishas as prostitutes. In a letter to a friend written in 1902, Albertus Peters, a crew-member of the U.S.S. Charleston, recorded: "Nagasaki is the first city I have ever

²⁷ DiGaetani: 117.

²⁸ Ibid.

visited where I could not find a place to eat and sleep and rest when coming ashore without having to do so in a saloon, a gambling den, or a house of ill repute, and that is saying a great deal, for I have spent three years traveling in foreign lands.”²⁹ The perspective of Nagasaki as a “recreational” destination for sailors not only provides insight to Pinkerton’s exploitative attitude towards Cio-Cio San, but also elucidates the profitability of Goro’s business practices as well as the validity of Sharpless’s moral trepidation. Imagine the quandary of conducting effective diplomacy with such a consistently exploited population.

Why did Puccini use such iconic American names as *Benjamin Franklin* Pinkerton, and the gunboat *Abraham Lincoln*? These names, as stated by DiGaetani, “exemplify America’s most appealing idealism in personal liberty and race relations: it creates a ‘special irony’ that Pinkerton’s behavior exemplifies the opposite of what these men stood for.” The choice of the names used was not Puccini’s, nor was it the decision of Illica and Giacosa. He used them because David Belasco and John Luther Long had used them first. Belasco and Long were both Americans making an anti-imperialist statement. This is a fact that reminds us that imperialism was never as popular with the American public as it seemed to be with the elected officials.

Pinkerton’s selfish behavior and imperialist approach is manifested in his Act I aria and duet with Sharpless in which he characterizes himself as a “*Yankee vagabondo*” who “wanders from country to country” with a condescending attitude toward foreigners, flexible in his adaptability to their customs, and mindful only of his own pleasure and profit.”³⁰ The older, more experienced Sharpless attempts to set Pinkerton straight by suggesting that Pinkerton’s perspective

²⁹ Groos, Arthur, and Giacomo Puccini. *Madama Butterfly*, fonti e documenti della genesi. Lucca: Centro studi Giacomo Puccini, 2005: 12.

³⁰ DiGaetani: 118.

is an “easy gospel, but it saddens the heart.” Consul Sharpless, in this statement, as well as in several others made in the first act regarding the consequences of Pinkerton’s foolish behavior, is later discovered as remarkably divinatory. As an American diplomat working at an R & R port such as Nagasaki, Sharpless undoubtedly has had to conduct damage control in more than one case of an irresponsible sailor causing harm to locals and disrespecting sacred customs. He seems to know what is coming and he does what he can to prevent it. The interaction here between Pinkerton and Sharpless suggests a “political paradigm: thoughtless military force insensitive to the conscience of the diplomatic mission which is, ultimately, impotent before such power.”³¹

Puccini takes the opportunity here to borrow a popular American melody to indicate a nationalistic contrast to the many Japanese melodies borrowed for *Butterfly*. Among them is the current American national anthem. *The Star-Spangled Banner*, however, was not the official anthem at the turn of the century. A popular patriotic song with poetry by Francis Scott Key and set to the melody of John Stafford Smith’s “The Anacreontic Song,” *The Star-Spangled Banner* was recognized as an official Navy hymn in 1889, but was not named the national anthem until a congressional resolution was signed by President Herbert Hoover on 3 March, 1931. From then, the Puccini borrowing has given Pinkerton and Sharpless an even more extreme nationalistic and imperialistic subtext as they sing “*America forever*” in English to the borrowed patriotic melody during their Act I duet.

Following Sharpless’s gentle reprimand of the dangers of Pinkerton’s condescending, exploitative attitude, Pinkerton nonchalantly defends his position by saying that men of such ad-

³¹ DiGaetani: 119.

vanced age cannot remember the pleasures of love, then toasts to the egocentric sentiment that he looks forward to a future date when he can marry a real American wife. At this moment, we hear the meter change and Puccini deploys the “Echigo Jishi” tune for the entrance of Butterfly and her friends. Ralph Locke, in his article on broadening the view of exoticism, states: “The sequence of musicalized events—Pinkerton’s heartless vow, Butterfly’s floating entrance and graceful landing—castigates Pinkerton’s selfishness and hypocrisy. By extension, it also castigates the imperial system that has brought Pinkerton to this distant land with dollars enough in his pocket to turn matters to his own advantage.”³² DiGaetani considers it “a musical juxtaposition that emphasizes the opera’s conflict of American and Japanese values.”³³ As Puccini’s *primo tenore* and poster boy for American imperialism, Pinkerton is uncommonly coarse. The first thing he asks Goro at the beginning of the opera is where the bed is located. During the wedding ceremony he continuously urges Goro to “*fate presto*” (to hurry). Pinkerton is clearly eager to get the young Butterfly into bed. The troubling sense of exploitation is unmistakable. It is interesting to note that in both literary sources, as well as the original Milan version of the opera (which premiered at La Scala to a devastatingly negative public response and was later revised to be premiered in Brescia) there is a moment in which Cio-Cio San admits that she initially feared the match with Pinkerton because she had equated Americans with Barbarians. In this case, she would have benefited from obeying her instincts.

Another ill omen is presented to Cio-Cio San during the first act. During the love duet, following the wedding ceremony, Cio-Cio San recounts to Pinkerton having heard that in Ameri-

³² Locke, Ralph P. 2007. "A Broader View of Musical Exoticism". *The Journal of Musicology*. 24, no. 4: 516.

³³ DiGaetani: 119.

ca, butterflies are pinned to a board for display in a collection. Pinkerton's response "so they will not fly away" as well as his earlier assertion that a "*Yankee vagabondo*" is not satisfied unless he "*fa suo tesoro i fiori d'ogni plaga, d'ogni bella gli amor*" (makes his treasure the flower of every region, of every beauty the love) hints at something that Butterfly does not yet know. She, too, is simply part of a collection; her wings pinned and unable to fly. Sharpless prophesies this metaphorical clipping of Cio-Cio San's wings when he advises Pinkerton that "it would be a great pity to tear those light wings and lay waste to a believing heart."³⁴ DiGaetani calls Pinkerton the perfect imperialist villain... for his status as villain is not known until it is too late.³⁵ He is a handsome, wealthy, sharply-dressed young man who "promises not exploitation but a loving partnership that represents progress and mutual happiness."³⁶

In Act III, when Pinkerton and his American wife, Kate return to Nagasaki to take the child back to America, promising a better life, Puccini employs an interesting technique that places more importance on the music than the text, and further reinforces the anti-imperialist frame of reference. If one reads the Act III libretto, the final trio of the opera, *Io so ch'alle sue pene*, encounters Sharpless pleading with Suzuki to convince Cio-Cio San to give up her child to the care of Kate Pinkerton, while Suzuki protests and Pinkerton wanders around the room muttering about the things in his line of sight that remind him of his time with Butterfly: the flowers, the bedroom, and his own portrait. The musical setting, however, paints a very different picture of the scene. Locke explains:

³⁴ Puccini, Giacomo, and Nico Castel. *The Complete Puccini Libretti*. Geneseo, N.Y.: Leyerle, 1994: 302.

³⁵ DiGaetani: 120.

³⁶ *Ibid.*

The music enacts a very different scenario, reflecting the power relations of imperialism. Throughout the 30 slow (*largo*) measures of the trio, the orchestra plays a quietly surging and even unfurling melody. Sharpless and Pinkerton take turns doubling the orchestra's melody. Beginning softly and *dolce*, they gradually build to an immense climax, at which the tenor holds a four-beat-long high B-flat. The baritone finally joins him on his own equally intense high F. It is not Pinkerton but Suzuki who is, throughout most of the trio, reduced to muttering. Her protesting words, mostly set as recitative-like interjections, seem to bounce ineffectually off the seamless wall of male legato singing (Example 7)... One imagines that the two men think their Western cultural values are superior to those of the Japanese. Pinkerton, after all, had ridiculed the Bonze in Act I. Yet here they prove themselves to be as deaf to a Japanese woman's entreaty—as unlistening—as was the Bonze on that former occasion.³⁷

Example 7. Puccini, *Madama Butterfly*, Act II, scene 2 trio: Pinkerton and Sharpless ignore Suzuki's concerned protestations.

Largo ♩ = 54
SUZUKI
 3
 E vo - le - te ch'io chie-da ad u - na ma - dre ...

PINKERTON
cresc.
 -ta - ta è la stan - za dei no - stri a-mor ...

SHARPLESS
 -vrà. Suv - vi - a

p cresc.

³⁷ Locke: 517-518.

At the end of the opera, Puccini and his librettists added one more anti-American touch to the score's stage directions. Though ignored in most modern stagings, prior to committing harakiri offstage, Cio-Cio-San places a small American flag in her son's hand. Butterfly's death is juxtaposed with her small boy waving the flag of his father. "While most audiences see the scene as merely one of pathos, the symbolic intent is clearly to remind the viewer of the ultimate villain: American imperialism in the orient."³⁸

Following in the footsteps of John Luther Long and David Belasco, Giacomo Puccini imbued the *Butterfly* tragedy with his own touch of skill and charm. A story that was born of an Eastern vs. Western conflict became an opera in which Puccini delved deep into the trove of Japanese popular tunes for the characterization of the psychological inner battles of its characters, specifically Puccini's favorite, Cio-Cio San herself. Though he strayed from his quest for authenticity on a few occasions, Puccini's dedication to *Madama Butterfly* was complete. From his reaction at the original viewing of the Belasco play in London to his depression after the disastrous La Scala premiere, it is clear that Puccini was invested in his heroine and her harrowing tale. His was not a case of appealing to the masses taken up in the exoticism and Japonisme movements. He always concerned himself with telling the story, and chose musical borrowings that would best represent his characters, their psyches, and their environments.

Though he cared much for the Japanese characters of the opera, it was not lost on him that Long's short story and Belasco's play were works of anti-imperialist protest. He knew that if not for the American imperialist agenda and deep-seeded colonial condescension, Butterfly's fate might be different. Puccini, however, allowed for a sympathetic Sharpless to soften the blow of

³⁸ DiGaetani: 24.

the anti-imperialist message. Even the concealed villain Pinkerton, in Act III, seems to have gained some compassion and understanding. By studying Puccini's masterpiece, we learn that the "easy gospel" of prejudice, racism, condescension, and exploitation can only "sadden the heart."³⁹

³⁹ Castel: 302.